became the first country to return to Afghanistan after being the last to leave in 1996. To ensure continuity of the partisan approach that India had adopted throughout late 1990s, Katju was recalled from his ambassadorship in Yangon to serve in Kabul.[11] Pakistan, on the other hand, was entering the first phase of a tortuous journey that involved simultaneous balancing of relations with the US, many angry jihadists, and an aggressive India. The alacrity with which the Indian team reached Bagram and subsequent visits by Abdullah, Qanooni, and Dostum to New Delhi raised the specter of Pakistan's non-cooperation in Afghanistan. To assuage the situation, Washington pushed Dostum and other Afghan leaders to undertake a similar visit to Islamabad, while Brahimi pressured Abdullah not to seek Indian support.[12] The US and the UN also agreed to focus on the six plus two and P-5 countries at Bonn, which excluded India. Despite the fact that India rejected US requests for troops on the ground (US PACOM Chief Admiral Dennis Blair was in India around the same time as the Kunduz airlift), New Delhi criticised the US for getting two-timed by Pakistan.[13] Having engaged Washington along partisan lines all these years, geography had failed India in the ultimate analysis. Despite being a preferred long-term strategic partner of the US in South Asia, India's value in the Afghan war was limited at best. The limited role of the US during Operation Parakram further underlined the limits of India's anti-Pakistan partisanship.

Nonetheless, the heyday of the Afghan war also highlighted that despite being limited, India's presence was indispensable in Afghanistan. Any attempt to exclude India would be counter-productive if the aim was to stabilise Afghanistan. And the harder Pakistan tried to marginalise India in Afghanistan, the stronger New Delhi's resolve became in maintaining (and expanding) its presence in Kabul and containing Pakistan's influence—adding to already high levels of mistrust between the two South Asian rivals. Not surprisingly, years later, in December 2015, after months of heavy firing along the Line-of-Control, the Lashkar-e-Taiba's inability to substantially infiltrate into Indian-administered Kashmir, the Afghan Taliban's failed attempts to capture Kunduz and the Kandahar airfield, and after tremendous attempts to engage with India on bilateral disputes, Pakistan invited New Delhi to moot on Afghanistan. These talks allowed the concretisation of the Comprehensive Bilateral Dialogue